



# ACE

ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT

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A FOUNDING DOCUMENT

## **THE UNANIMOUS DECLARATION OF THE ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT**

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*A declaration of the causes and the course that follows from them*

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Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development

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*For Our People, By Our People*



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When in the course of human events it becomes necessary for a people to dissolve political bonds that have kept them in a condition their own government created and never repaired, separation becomes a necessary course. They must then withdraw from the authority that has governed them and assume responsibility for their own human, civic, and political future. Such a decision carries with it an obligation to state plainly the conditions that made it necessary.

In response, the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development, a coalition formed around the cause of Black self-determination and cooperation with willing Native nations and communities, holds that the governing order under which our people have lived has exhausted any claim upon our continued patience. Across four centuries, the institutions that became and comprise the United States of America have repeatedly treated Black people as instruments of their wealth rather than citizens entitled to the full measure of the principles they professed. The record which follows will show this to be no rash conclusion, but a plain and documented history of what was done, what was permitted, what was promised, and what remains unresolved.

The history set forth here is a history of deliberate injuries, exclusions, and denials that have shaped the human, civic, economic, and political condition of our people across generations. These are not grievances offered without evidence, nor conclusions reached in haste. To prove them, let facts be submitted to a candid world.

It has held human beings as property, torn from their homeland and consigned to bondage, for two hundred fifty years, extracting their labor to build the wealth of a nation that denied them any share in it.

It has stripped human beings of their names, replacing them with names not their own, and of their languages, forbidding by law that they be taught to read or write in any tongue at all. It has suppressed the religions they carried with them from their homeland and required, under laws mandating white supervision of every gathering, that they take up the faith of the very people who held them in bondage, until the god they had known was replaced by the god their captors demanded they answer to instead.

It has, upon the nominal end of slavery, enacted Black Codes and vagrancy laws for the specific purpose of returning the newly freed to bondage in fact where it could no longer hold them in bondage by name.



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It has operated a system of convict leasing that continued slavery's labor and its profit under the cover of law, arresting the freed for invented offenses and selling their labor to the same interests that had owned them before.

It has promised forty acres to those it had enslaved, formalized that promise in Special Field Order No. 15, and revoked it within the year, before the greater part of that promise could reach a single family it was made to.

It has, through decades of Jim Crow law, used the machinery of the state itself to enforce the exclusion of Black Americans from the vote, from the courts, from public office, and from every institution capable of building independent political and economic power.

It has redlined Black neighborhoods by official federal policy, denying generations the mortgage capital that built the wealth of every other American community, and has watched the wealth gap that policy created persist to this day without remedy.

It has declared urban renewal upon Black neighborhoods and demolished them for highways and stadiums built for others, displacing families and severing communities that had taken generations to build.

It has waged a war on drugs and a policy of mass incarceration that has imprisoned Black Americans at a rate the rest of the world has no parallel for, extracting labor from prisoners under an exception written into its own Constitution.

It has, toward the Native peoples of this land, waged war, broken every treaty it signed, and removed nations at gunpoint from the land those nations had occupied since memory.

It has enacted a policy of termination and allotment against Native nations, dissolving recognized tribal governments and dividing communal land into parcels designed to be sold away from the people who held it.

It has removed Native children from their families and placed them in boarding schools built on the stated purpose, in the words of the man who founded the first of them, to "kill the Indian and save the man," a policy of cultural extermination carried out against Native children for generations.



It has, under the Code of Indian Offenses of 1883, made Native religious ceremonies a federal crime, punishing those who practiced their faith or sought their own spiritual and medical traditions with imprisonment and the withholding of food, a policy of religious criminalization that stood for ninety-five years until its repeal in 1978.

It has offered this same government's own courts as the only forum for remedy, courts that have upheld the property it stole and left both peoples to petition a system with no incentive to answer them.

In every stage of these acts of oppression, we have petitioned for redress in the most humble terms. Our repeated petitions have been answered only by further oppression.

Separation, not segregation, is necessary. Segregation was imposed from outside: a dominant power using law and force to exclude a people from institutions they were never permitted to share equally, while continuing to govern them and control the terms of their exclusion. Separation, by contrast, is chosen from within: a people consciously withdrawing their governance, planning, and institution-building from the reach of a power that has repeatedly shown itself willing to exploit, manipulate, destroy, and even extinguish the very idea of their freedom.

Understanding this, a people cannot prudently rebuild under the supervision of the power that created the ruin. Nor can reconstruction remain dependent upon those whose interests are threatened by its success. The hand that produced the condition cannot be permitted a place in the conversation, a seat at the table, a voice in defining the remedy, or any role in shaping, directing, financing, governing, or redirecting what is built. The process of reconstruction must belong entirely to the people whose condition made it necessary.

We, therefore, the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development, on behalf of the members who join this cause, do solemnly publish and declare that we hold the right to govern ourselves, to build our own institutions, and to hold land, wealth, and sovereignty through institutions of our own making, free from dependence on a government that, across four centuries, has failed to extend to us in practice what it has claimed in principle to owe every citizen. We do not declare this in anger, and we do not declare it in haste. We declare it because the



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record set forth above leaves no honest alternative, and because a people who have waited this long have earned the right to stop waiting.

What is declared here is not declared for a season. The work of building it is a twenty-five-year undertaking, carried out in phases, but what that work brings into existence is intended to endure. A nation does not cease when the work of its founding generation is complete; what they establish is entrusted to those who follow.

To this undertaking, this Alliance and its members pledge every resource they can command, every year required, and every hand willing to build alongside them. To what is established through that work, they pledge their continued protection, stewardship, and preservation for the generations that follow, and without end.



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